

The Rise of Nationalism in Europe

Social Science — History • Chapter 1 • Chapter Summary & Study Guide for Daksh

In the year 1848, a French artist named **Frédéric Sorrieu** drew a series of prints showing 'a world made up of democratic and social Republics'. Men and women of all ages and social classes marched in a long procession, paying homage to the Statue of Liberty. The prints captured a powerful new idea — **nationalism** — that swept across 19th-century Europe. This chapter traces how the idea of the nation-state emerged in Europe through the French Revolution, the wars of unification of Italy and Germany, and the Balkan crisis.

The French Revolution and the idea of the nation

The **French Revolution (1789)** was the first clear expression of nationalism. It transferred sovereignty from the monarchy to the body of French citizens. Steps it took to forge a sense of collective identity:

- Ideas of *la patrie* (the fatherland) and *le citoyen* (the citizen) — emphasising a united community of equal rights.
- A new French flag — the tricolour — replacing the royal standard.
- The Estates General was elected and renamed the National Assembly.
- New hymns composed, oaths taken, martyrs commemorated, all in the name of the nation.
- A centralised administrative system, uniform laws (the **Napoleonic Code**, 1804), abolition of feudal privileges, equality before law, secured right to property.

Napoleon carried these ideas across Europe through his conquests. While he ended monarchies, he also imposed French rule, censorship and heavy taxes — leading to mixed feelings in occupied territories.

The making of nationalism in Europe

Before nationalism, most of Europe was a patchwork of kingdoms, duchies and empires (Habsburg Empire, Austria-Hungary, Ottoman Empire). The new **middle class** — educated, liberal, professional — championed nationalism. Liberal nationalism stood for:

- **Politically**: government by consent, end of autocracy, equality before law, a written constitution.
- **Economically**: freedom of markets, abolition of trade restrictions. The **Zollverein** (1834) was a customs union of German states that abolished tariffs — preparing the ground for unification.
- Spread through novels, songs, poetry, folk art (e.g. Grimm Brothers' tales as 'true German spirit').

The Revolutions of 1830 and 1848

After the fall of Napoleon, the conservative powers (Austria, Russia, Prussia, England) met at the **Congress of Vienna (1815)** chaired by **Duke Metternich** to restore monarchies. But nationalism could not be put back. The 1830s and 1848 saw waves of revolutions:

- **1830**: July Revolution in France toppled Bourbon king. Belgium broke away from the Netherlands. Greece won independence (Treaty of Constantinople, 1832) — supported by European Romantics like the poet Lord Byron.
- **1848**: Liberals demanded constitutions, parliamentary government, freedom of press across Europe. In France, the king abdicated; in Frankfurt, a German Parliament met. Most of these revolutions failed but laid the foundation for unification.
- **Romantic movement** emphasised emotions, intuition, folk culture as the soul of the nation. *Karol Kurpinski* in Poland turned folk dances into nationalist symbols; the Polish language was used as a weapon against Russian rule.

Unification of Italy and Germany

Two of the most spectacular nation-building stories of the 19th century:

ITALY (unified by 1871)

- Giuseppe Mazzini : ideologue
'Young Italy' (1831)
- Count Cavour : diplomat
PM of Sardinia-Piedmont, allied
with France against Austria.
- Garibaldi : soldier
Red Shirts captured Naples & Sicily.
- Victor Emmanuel II crowned king

GERMANY (unified by 1871)

- Otto von Bismarck : architect
'Blood and Iron' policy
- Three wars under Prussia:
vs Denmark (1864)
vs Austria (1866)
vs France (1870-71)
- Kaiser William I crowned
German Emperor at Versailles.

Britain — a different model

Britain was forged not by revolution but by gradual integration. The Act of Union (1707) joined England and Scotland; Ireland was incorporated in 1801. Symbols — the British flag, anthem, English language — were promoted as a single national identity, often suppressing Scottish and Irish cultures.

Visualising the nation and the Balkan question

Artists portrayed nations as **female allegories** — Marianne (France), Germania (Germany) — symbolising the people's collective identity. By the late 19th century, however, nationalism turned aggressive. The **Balkans** (Greece, Romania, Bulgaria, Serbia, Montenegro), under the declining Ottoman Empire, became a tinderbox of competing nationalisms. The Great Powers (Russia, Germany, England, Austro-Hungary) intervened for their own gains. This Balkan crisis was a major cause of the **First World War (1914)**. By then, nationalism had moved from a unifying force to a deeply divisive one.

★ MUST-REMEMBER POINTS

- French Revolution (1789) introduced ideas of nation, citizen, fatherland.
- Napoleonic Code (1804) — uniform civil law, equality before law.
- Congress of Vienna (1815) under Metternich — restored monarchies.
- Italy unified by 1871 — three figures: Mazzini (idea), Cavour (diplomacy), Garibaldi (army).
- Germany unified by 1871 — Bismarck's 'Blood and Iron' policy; three wars (Denmark, Austria, France).
- Zollverein (1834) — customs union that prepared German economic unification.
- Marianne = France; Germania = Germany. Balkan nationalism led to WWI (1914).

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